Department of Curriculum and Instruction
M.Ed. Final Project Requirements and Examples

The M.Ed. final project provides students with an opportunity to design and implement an independent project in the schools or field that utilizes/reflects ideas and concepts from courses taken in the M.Ed. program. Students in the M.Ed. programs register for an independent study course in conjunction with the project (e.g., CI 5186, 5187, CI 5190) during the semester that they intend to finish the project and turn in a final written report. The project should be the last program requirement.

The M.Ed. project is one paper involving *a total of approximately 120 hours* of work and approximately 20-30 pages. A proposal for the paper should be written and presented to the adviser for approval before student begins work on the paper. The project may or may not involve IRB approval, but should involve (1) inquiry and (2) substantial self-reflection on the student's part.

This independent inquiry-based project can take many forms including:

- an investigation of a specific problem in a classroom or school or community or business organization,
- an informal action research project,
- the design and evaluation of a new curriculum unit or course,
- an investigation of an issue related to students or teachers in an educational context,
- testing out a new teaching technique in the classroom

M.Ed. Project Proposal:

Suggested contents of the project proposal include the following:

Purpose of the Project
- Description of the problem or issue the student is studying and the purpose of and rationale for the project.

Literature Review
- Preliminary outline of the literature related to the proposed project. (Note: even in the case of the development of a curriculum unit, students must refer to readings.)

Proposed "Method"
- A written description of the project plan including the research question and a description of at least one data source.
- Include information on the teaching or other context (i.e. number of students, type, setting, school, type of course, etc.)
- A description of the key features of instruction, including an overview of the unit, or any other relevant information that would help the reader understand the context.

Appendix
- If applicable, Human Subjects Application: http://www.irb.umn.edu/

Final Project Text:

The final project should include the following:

Purpose of and Rationale for the Project/Inquiry

- Description of the problem or issue the student is studying and the purpose of and rationale for the project.

Literature Review (may be a separate section or literature may be cited instead throughout the paper)

- Overview of the literature related to the proposed project. (Note: even in the case of curriculum development, students must refer to readings, though they may appear in the context of the unit itself rather than a separate section.)

Description of the Project

- Include information on the teaching or other context (i.e. number of students, type, setting, school, type of course, etc.)
- A written description of the project plan including goals, content, method(s) used, how the student analyzed the data (if applicable).

Description of the Results and Implications

- Description of what was learned from the inquiry project; this section needs to involve substantial reflection on the student's part. How will s/he use what was learned? How will his/her practice change as a result of the inquiry?

Bibliography, Resources and Appendices (if applicable)

- Include full bibliographic information for all of the sources cited and resources used.
- If applicable, copy of the approval letter from the U of MN IRB.

Examples of Papers Showing M.Ed. Final Project Effort and Quality:

Curriculum Inquiry: A teacher writes a new curriculum unit. He could teach the unit in his class and collect information about student or teacher attitudes toward the unit or do a self-reflection on the process. In this case he might: 1) administer an anonymous written survey to students, or 2) ask colleagues to read the unit and offer written or oral feedback, or 3) keep a journal during the course of writing the unit and teaching it; then, after completing the unit and carrying it out with students, the teacher writes a meta-reflection on the process—what went well? what would you change based on student responses to activities and lessons? what was challenging about writing the unit? how did your coursework for the M.Ed. help prepare you for the unit? (involves IRB approval if student data are collected)

Informal Action Research Project: A Kindergarten language immersion teacher is interested in exploring different ways to provide corrective feedback to students when they make errors. She decides to focus on a grammatical feature appropriate for young learners—the placement of adjectives. (In Spanish adjectives come after the noun and in English they come before the noun, so initially the different word order is difficult for young learners.) She creates some games that would elicit noun/adjective utterances and videotapes students playing the games and her providing feedback when they make errors. She looks at the number of times students self-correct their errors based on the feedback she gives them. (involves IRB approval)